

if you decide to have a home bar? First, depending on space, you need to take a call on whether you want a free-standing bar (a dedicated bar counter complete with bar stools behind which you can display your cocktail-making skills) or a bar cabinet. “If you are short on space just go for a bar as a piece of furniture. This can be a cupboard or a cabinet,” says Shalini Misra, a London-based interior designer who divides her time between London and India. She ideally designs them 1.6 metres in height. Her focus is on the cupboard doors. These can have art on them, or framed fabric or even mirrors. “We always use beautiful handles because they tell a different story,” she says. The inside of the cupboard doors are used for storage of glasses or bottles. At around 90 cm in height, there is a pull-out table. “This becomes your workstation. Below that there are two or three drawers for other equipment and then the wine rack,” says Misra.

If, on the other hand, you have the space, then a part of the room can be made into a bar. The minimum space required is 1 metre, which can accommodate two stools. Singhal, who besides selling ready-made bars also customises home bars, says the sky is the limit when it comes to designing a home bar and it all depends on your budget and the space you have. One of his most interesting projects was in Ahmedabad where the younger generation living in a joint family wanted a bar but were respectful of the reservations of the older generation and, therefore, did not want the alcohol to be seen. Singhal’s team used hydraulic presses which at the touch of a button would bring the bottles to bar level, else they were hidden from sight. He also recently designed a bar inside a swimming pool at a farmhouse in Delhi. “One of my most challenging projects was designing a bar on the 36th floor of a corporate house in Mumbai. That’s where the helipad is. The wind factor

is so high you feel you will be blown away,” says Singhal.

The ideal height of a bar is 4 ft so that when you sit on a stool your elbows can rest on the bar. Singhal says there is a demand for beer on tap at home bars but since beer kegs are still not available in India for sale, they don’t really work.

When setting up the physical bar you also need to decide whether it’s going to be a wet bar (that is one

with a drainage connection) or a dry bar. Another thing to look out for is if you want a mini fridge or an ice dispenser at the bar.

Once your physical bar is ready, it is time to set it up. “Start by planning out your work area,” suggests Vikram Achanta, Founder and CEO of beverage training and consultancy firm Tulleeho. For beginners he recommends purchasing basic bar equipment that includes a three-

